Lecture 3: Political Regimes (FK)

Political Science — Master Notes · by Jakob V. Stangel

Required reading: OD ch. 3 (*States, Citizens, and Regimes*)

Theme of the lecture (Filip Kiil): ch. 2 asked *what a state is*; ch. 3 asks *what kind of government rules it* — the **regime** — and sorts regimes by the **ideology** that answers **who may rule and what rights citizens get.**

Lecture frame (FK) — the State–Regime–Citizen(–Ideology) nexus

Core: four linked concepts; the **regime** sits between the permanent **state** and the current **government**, and is classified by its **ideology**.

- **State** — the ongoing administrative apparatus (ch. 2); most enduring.
- **Regime** — the formal **+ informal** institutions defining the *type* of government; more enduring than governments, less than the state. *(US: 46 administrations, one democratic regime since 1789; Nigeria: 8 regimes.)*
- **Citizen** — a member of the political community with **rights + duties** (vs a *subject*, who has only duties/obedience).
- **Ideology** — defines the **state–citizen relationship** and is how we classify regimes — but regimes often **diverge** from their ideology (informal institutions dominate, especially in weak states).

The V-Dem / "Regimes of the World" ladder (Lührmann, Tannenberg & Lindberg 2018) — the modern measure the lecture uses:

Regime	Multi-party elections?	Free & fair?	Rights + checks on the executive?
Closed autocracy	No	—	No
Electoral autocracy	Yes	**No** (restrictions undermine fairness)	No
Electoral democracy	Yes	**Yes**	Partial
Liberal democracy	Yes	Yes	**Yes** (rights, legal equality, checks)

Explaining regime *change* (the same **Interests / Beliefs / Structures** lens from Lecture 1):

Lens	How it explains change
Interests	Elites expand/restrict democracy to maximise power (democratise post-1990 for aid; **backslide** when power is threatened).
Beliefs	Democratic ideals spread in 19th–20th c.; fascism/communism caused reversals; recent **populism** erodes liberal values.
Structures	Industrialisation enabled democratisation; Cold War blocs sustained autocracy; globalisation/inequality now strain democracy.

OD Ch. 3 — States, Citizens, and Regimes

Book: Orvis & Drogus, *Introducing Comparative Politics*, 5th ed., ch. 3.

Chapter résumé

Examines the **state↔people** relationship as embodied in different **regimes** — the formal + informal institutions defining a *type* of government. It traces the rise of the "**citizen**" (vs "subject") and of **civil society**, presents **T.H. Marshall's** three rights of citizenship (civil, political, social), then gives the chapter's core: a **taxonomy of regime types classified by ideology** — liberal democracy, communism, fascism, modernizing authoritarianism, personalist, electoral authoritarianism, theocracy. A recurring thread: **no regime works exactly as its ideology claims** — informal institutions often matter more.

> ★ **The heart of the chapter:** a **regime** = the formal + informal institutions defining a *type* of government, classified by its **ideology**. The single axis that orders them all: **how much power goes to citizens vs. the state. Liberal democracy** (limited state, broad rights) is the benchmark; every other regime tilts power toward the state and restricts full citizenship to a select group.

The red thread. Read the whole chapter as answers to **one question — *how is power shared between citizens and the state?*** Liberal democracy shares it widely (limited government + Marshall's rights); communism, fascism, modernizing & electoral authoritarianism, and theocracy concentrate it (in the party / a leader / a developing elite / God), restricting full citizenship to the working class / loyal nationals / the developers / the faithful. For **every** regime type ask: **who has power, and what rights do citizens get?**

Key concepts / "modes" to use

- **State vs regime vs government** — continuous apparatus / *type* of government / current occupants.
- **Citizen vs subject** — rights + duties vs duties only.
- **Marshall's three rights** — **civil · political · social** (the yardstick for "full" citizenship).
- **Ideology-based regime taxonomy** — the seven types (below).
- **Dahl's 8 guarantees** — the working definition of liberal democracy.

- **Formal vs informal institutions** — informal rules (patronage, factions) often explain how a regime *really* works.

Section-by-section main points

Citizens & civil society

Core: modern politics invented the **citizen** (rights + duties) out of the **subject** (obedience only) — and full citizenship needs all three of **Marshall's rights**.

- **Citizen vs subject:** 200–300 years ago Europeans were **subjects** of absolutist monarchs (no mechanism to protect "rights"); citizenship arose as sovereignty moved from the monarch to "**the people**" (after the French Revolution people addressed each other as "*citizen*").
- **Marshall (1963) — three rights: civil** (individual freedom, fair treatment) · **political** (participation, vote) · **social** (welfare, socioeconomic equality). Full citizenship needs *enough* social equality to make civil/political equality real. **Virtually no country fully provides all three.**
- **Civil society** — organised, nongovernmental, nonviolent activity by groups larger than families/firms; impossible under absolutism, enabled by religious pluralism + capitalism.
- **Popular sovereignty** — even dictators claim to rule *on behalf of* the people (theocracy claims God willed the exception). Emerging **postnational** citizenship (EU, ICC) — but core rights still sit in the **nation-state**.

Regimes, ideologies & citizens

Core: regimes are classified by **ideology**, but never match it perfectly — **informal institutions** often dominate (especially in weak states).

- Liberal democracy is the **benchmark all regimes respond to**: **~90% of the world's constitutions** — including authoritarian ones — mention "democracy" (Elkins et al. 2014).

The regime taxonomy — *memorise this (the exam core)*

Core: seven regime types, each defined by an ideology answering **who has power** and **what citizens get**.

Regime	Key idea	Who has power
Liberal democracy	Individuals free with natural rights; govt must preserve **life, liberty, property**	The **legislature** (elected, removable)
Communism	Historical materialism → proletarian revolution → classless, stateless society	**Vanguard party** now; the proletariat "later"
Fascism	Organic society; the **state creates the nation**; corporatism	A **supreme leader**
Modernizing authoritarianism	*Development* needs unity, so democracy must wait	A **modern (educated) elite**
Personalist regime	Claims to modernise but is really **neopatrimonial**	An **individual ruler**
Electoral authoritarianism	Blends democratic + authoritarian legitimacy	The **ruling party** (via rigged elections)
Theocracy	Rule by **divine** authority (Islamism → sharia)	**God** (via the clergy) — not the people

Liberal democracy

Core: **liberal democracy = democracy (rule by the people) + liberalism (individual rights)** — a *limited* state that protects rights and holds free, competitive elections.

- **Roots:** liberalism arose in the 16th–17th-c. religious wars; **social contract theory** (Hobbes, Locke, Montesquieu, Rousseau). **Locke:** government is legitimate only if it preserves **life, liberty, property** (Jefferson → "pursuit of happiness"). Democracy was added later; early liberals limited citizenship to **male property owners** — expanded over the 19th–20th c.
- **Dahl's 8 guarantees** (the working definition): freedom of **association** · **expression** · right to **vote** · broad **office eligibility** · leaders' right to **compete** · alternative **information** · **free & fair elections** · institutions that make policy **depend on votes**.
- **Varieties of democracy: liberal** (political rights — UK) · **social democracy** (adds economic regulation + social rights — Sweden; a variant *within* liberal democracy) · **participatory** (direct involvement beyond voting — Switzerland).

Communism

Core: **Marx's historical materialism** — economic forces drive history — predicts a proletarian revolution ending in a classless, stateless utopia; in practice it produced the **totalitarian state**.

- **Feudalism → capitalism → socialism → communism.** Liberal democracy is a "shell" for capitalism; liberal rights = "*equal rights for unequal people.*"
- **Stages: socialism** = collective ownership + **dictatorship of the proletariat** (a *class* dictatorship) → eventually stateless, classless **communism** (human nature itself changes).
- **Critique:** any theory promising utopia tends toward the **totalitarian state** (Russia/Stalin case).

Fascism

Core: **antiliberal *and* anticommunist** — the **state creates and embodies the nation**; the individual exists only for the state; citizens have **duties, not rights**.

- **Organic** conception of society; a **supreme leader** embodies the nation. **Corporatism:** one state-controlled organisation per sector (one union, one business association). Rejects rationality/materialism → glorifies struggle & war → **totalitarian** (Nazi Germany case).

Modernizing authoritarianism

Core: legitimacy through **development, not rights** — a **modern elite** must guide progress, and democracy would only interfere.

- **Technocratic legitimacy** rooted in **modernization theory** (postcolonial states must follow the West's path). **Four institutional forms: one-party** (civilian; postcolonial Africa/Asia — Tanzania) · **military** (coup — Brazil) · **bureaucratic-authoritarian** · **personalist**.

Personalist regimes

Core: in the **weakest states**, one leader captures everything — even the party/military that raised him — via **neopatrimonial** patron–client loyalty rather than institutions.

- Weak, unstable, unpredictable; rule of law inconsistent. Most common in Africa (Mobutu, Marcos, Abacha/Nigeria).

Electoral authoritarianism (hybrid)

Core: a **hybrid** — real opposition and elections *exist*, but the ruling party **manipulates the rules** so it never actually loses; it **proclaims itself democratic.**

- Blends liberal-democratic (elections) + modernizing-authoritarian (limits for "stability/development") legitimacy. Spread after the Cold War because open authoritarianism lost international legitimacy (Mexico/PRI case).

Theocracy

Core: **rule by religious authorities on behalf of God** — so ultimate sovereignty is **Allah's, not the people's.**

- **Islamism** (a 19th–20th-c. reaction to Western imperialism, *not* traditional): sharia should be the basis of government. Key terms: **sharia** (law) · **ijtihad** (individual interpretation) vs **taqlid** (blind acceptance) · **shura** (consultation — the opening for quasi-democracy) · **umma** (community) · **jihad** (three kinds: inner struggle [most important] → righting injustice → armed defence [least]). Iran is the world's **only true theocracy** (Iran case).

Cases & examples

Why these cases are here — circle them back. Each country is a **worked example of one regime type**; read every case for **(1) which type · (2) who has power · (3) what rights citizens get.** The table

maps case → type; the write-ups tell the story.

Case	Regime type	Who has power	Freedom House
UK	Liberal democracy	Parliament (sovereign)	Free
Russia/USSR	Communism → (now electoral authoritarian)	Vanguard party / Stalin	Not Free
Germany (Nazi)	Fascism	A supreme leader	*(Free today)*
Brazil	Modernizing authoritarian (military)	Technocratic military elite	Free (today)
Nigeria (Abacha)	Personalist	One ruler (neopatrimonial)	Partly Free
Mexico (PRI)	Electoral authoritarian	The ruling party	Partly Free
Iran	Theocracy	God (via the clergy)	Not Free
Tanzania	Modernizing authoritarian (one-party)	A single party	—

- **United Kingdom — "cradle of democracy."** Liberal democracy evolved **gradually, with no single written constitution** and no revolutionary break from monarchy: **Magna Carta (1215) → Glorious Revolution (1688) → Bill of Rights (1689)**; the franchise expanded only under pressure (1832 middle class ~7%; women's suffrage **1918**); recent **devolution (1997)**, a standalone **Supreme Court (2005)**. → *The first liberal democracy; power rests on **parliamentary sovereignty** (a powerful informal institution) + the slow build-up of all three Marshall rights.*
- **Russia/USSR — the first "communist" regime.** Revolution came in the "wrong country" (agrarian, not advanced-capitalist). **Lenin** added the **vanguard party** and led the **October Revolution 1917**; **Stalin** built a **totalitarian state** (rapid industrialisation, **2–20 million deaths**); **Gorbachev's** reforms → collapse **Dec 1991** into 15 states. → *Communism in practice = the totalitarian state; the regime diverged wildly from Marx's theory (Marx→Lenin→Stalin).*
- **Germany — the rise of the Nazis (fascism).** Hitler was **elected, not a coup** — the Nazis won **37% (1932)** amid depression; the **Reichstag fire (1933)** → Enabling Act → dictatorship; unions replaced by a party-controlled front (corporatism); Nazism fused fascism with **racism** → the **Holocaust (~6m Jews)**. → *Fascism + totalitarian state; its horror **delegitimised fascism globally**, though **neofascism** persists (Le Pen's National Front — 2nd in France's 2002 presidential race).*
- **Brazil — a military modernizing-authoritarian regime (1964–85).** A US-backed coup installed a **technocratic military** elite that staked legitimacy on **development + anticommunism** (National Security Doctrine); state-led industry produced the "**Brazilian Miracle**" **(1967–73)** but rising inequality. When growth stalled, unions + the Church revived civil society → **democracy restored 1985**. → *Modernizing authoritarianism in military form — legitimacy = development, so no growth = no legitimacy.*
- **Nigeria — Abacha's personalist regime (1993–98).** After the military annulled the **1993 election**, **General Abacha** seized power, gutted the courts, jailed/killed opponents (hanged poet **Ken Saro-Wiwa**), and **looted ~$3 billion** — ruling by **neopatrimonial** oil patronage. His **sudden death**

(1998) ended it; wary officers delivered the **democracy in place since 1999**. → *Personalist regime — a weak state's institutions crumble around one man.*

- **Mexico — the PRI (electoral authoritarianism).** The **PRI** ruled **~71 years** via regular *but rigged* elections — a **democratic veneer** over **clientelism, corporatism and fraud** (Tlatelolco Massacre **1968**), with power rotated among factions and presidents limited to one **sexenio**. Erosion (contested **1988**) → **Vicente Fox (PAN) broke the monopoly in 2000**. → *The classic hybrid regime — informal institutions (clientelism, fraud) dominate the formal democratic shell.*
- **Iran — the Islamic Republic (theocracy). Khomeini's 1979 revolution** built the first modern theocracy: a **Supreme Leader** (a cleric with veto power) + a **Guardian Council (12 clergy)** vetting all candidates/laws, *above* an elected president & parliament (**Majlis**). The **1979 constitution** makes **Allah sovereign** and sharia the sole law. → *Theocracy — permanent tension between **theocratic authority** and **quasi-democratic** elements (shura/elections).*
- **Tanzania — Nyerere's one-party regime. Julius Nyerere** ("Africa's philosopher-king") justified a **one-party** state by claiming Africa lacked class divisions; his **ujamaa** "African socialism" ruined agriculture but achieved **near-universal literacy**; he **voluntarily resigned (1985)**. → *Civilian **one-party** modernizing authoritarianism — the "development vs democracy" trade-off.*

Key terms

Term	Meaning
Regime	Formal + informal institutions defining a *type* of government
Citizen / Subject	Member with rights + duties / person with duties (obedience) only
Civil / Political / Social rights	Marshall's three: freedom & fair treatment / participation / welfare & equality
Civil society	Organised nongovernmental, nonviolent activity beyond family/firm
Social contract theory	Legitimate govt = free individuals contracting to be governed
Liberal democracy	Democracy + liberalism; Dahl's 8 guarantees
Social / Participatory democracy	Adds social rights & economic control / adds direct participation
Parliamentary sovereignty	Parliament is supreme (UK)
Historical materialism	Material/economic forces drive history (Marxism)
Dictatorship of the proletariat	First communist stage: rule by the working class
Totalitarian state	Controls ~all of society, eliminates civil society
Vanguard party	Lenin: elite party leading the proletariat
Corporatism	One state-controlled organisation per social sector
Modernizing authoritarianism	Legitimacy from "development" by a modern elite
Technocratic legitimacy	Right to rule based on expertise
Personalist regime / Neopatrimonial	One ruler dominates / power via personal patron–client loyalty
Electoral authoritarianism	Hybrid: opposition + elections, but rigged
Theocracy / Islamism	Rule by religious authority / sharia as the basis of government

Exam pointers

- Nail the **state / regime / government / citizen** distinctions + **Marshall's three rights** (civil/political/social) — the framing for any answer.
- Reproduce the **seven-type regime taxonomy** (key idea + **who has power**) — and answer everything through the red thread: *how is power shared between citizens and the state?*
- Define **liberal democracy via Dahl's 8 guarantees** + the **three varieties** (liberal/social/participatory).
- Distinguish the **authoritarian types** with a case each: communism (Russia) · fascism (Germany) · modernizing (Brazil/Tanzania) · personalist (Nigeria) · electoral authoritarian (Mexico) · theocracy (Iran).

- Use the **V-Dem ladder** (closed autocracy → electoral autocracy → electoral democracy → liberal democracy) and the **Interests/Beliefs/Structures** lens to discuss *regime change*.

★ Fun facts & memorable details

> Sticky stats, dates & quotes from Lecture 3 (regimes).

Quotable lines

- Mussolini: "*The State is all-embracing; outside of it no human or spiritual values can exist*" — and he openly embraced the label "**totalitarian.**"
- Marx: communism is "*a spectre haunting Europe*" (*Communist Manifesto*, 1848); liberal rights = "*equal rights for unequal people*."
- Nyerere: "*When a village of a hundred people have sat and talked together until they agreed where a well should be dug, they have practised democracy.*"
- Locke's core liberties = "**life, liberty and property**" → Jefferson's "**life, liberty and the pursuit of happiness.**"

Striking numbers

- **~90%** of the world's constitutions — including authoritarian ones — mention "democracy."
- **Dahl** = **8** guarantees of liberal democracy.
- Deaths under **Stalin**: estimated **2–20 million**; USSR dissolved **Dec 1991** into **15** states.
- Hitler's Nazis won **37% (1932)** and he was **elected** chancellor — not a coup; **~6 million** Jews killed.
- The **PRI** ruled **71 years**, winning **98% of local/congressional elections 1946–73** (and **98.7%** of the 1976 presidential vote).
- Iran's **Guardian Council = 12 clergy**; Iran is nearly all **Shiite**, though Sunnis are **~85%** of the world's Muslims.

Memorable facts

- The US has had **46 administrations but one regime** (since 1789); **Nigeria has had 8 regimes**.
- "**Kremlinology**" — analysts inferred Soviet power from who stood closest to the leader at parades.
- **Abacha** (Nigeria) looted ~**$3 billion** and hanged the poet **Ken Saro-Wiwa**.
- Le Pen's **National Front** came **2nd in France's 2002 presidential election** — neofascism didn't die with 1945.
- The **three jihads**: inner struggle (most important) → righting injustice in the *umma* → armed defence (least important) — the reverse of the popular Western image.
